



Beijing Normal University

BNU/SSDPP

School of Social Development and Public Policy

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January 2, 2023

To the Admission Committee:

It is a great pleasure for me to write this letter of recommendation for Mengnan Xu, who is applying to your program.

As Mengnan's academic advisor for her Master's and PhD studies at Beijing Normal University, I have worked closely with Mengnan for six years. I am very impressed by her capability, motivation and adaptability in learning new knowledge, methodologies and software skills.

Over the past 30 years, I have supervised quite a few Masters and PhD students, Mengnan is very unique. Not to mention that she has completed her three years Masters's program in two years with an outstanding 4.0 GPA and an excellent thesis, the important aspect is that she has an active mind and is interested in new research methods, in learning different statistical software and in computer programming.

Based on her excellent performance in her Master's study, I decided to take her into the PhD program to continue serving as her academic advisor. In addition to a 3.7 GPA for her required PhD coursework, she picked up SAS and python programming, and these skills have helped the big data project that I chaired with funding from the Gates Foundation. Together we worked on the evaluation of China's tobacco control policies, and established a big data platform which synthesized survey data, media and social media data, web-search data, sales data, and administrative data. We have co-authored articles including one published in BMJ (Q1). Her skills in data synthesis and modeling have been strengthened in hands-on analysis.

The Gates Foundation China tobacco control project is a \$5.5 million endorsement that I chaired. The partners include multiple government agencies such as the National Health Commission, Ministry of Finance, China Taxation Administration, State Council Research and Development Center and local health departments, non-profit organizations, and academic communities. Initially, Mengnan served as a research assistant for the project. Because her work involved data platform establishment, she undertook a lot of coordination effort with these organizations and helped the project manage several sub-

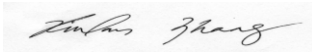
contracts. She is a very good team player, and worked with different teams including a data team, policy team, media team, and management team.

Because of her data skills, I relied on her to add two more projects to the bigdata platform: The China Tobacco Industry Watch and China National Social Organization Database.

In working with Mengnan, I can proudly say that she is very efficient, hardworking, and caring for other people. Her motivation, direction, strength of character, independence of mind, thoughtfulness, and discipline will make her a good candidate in almost everything she works for. Personally, I like Mengnan, like her personality, warm, confident, optimistic, friendly, and, ambitious.

I have no doubt that Mengnan will succeed in your program. She has the technical capability, professional ethics, and leadership the program is urging for. I enthusiastically recommend Mengnan to be accepted by your program. If I can be of any further help, please do not hesitate to call on me at zhang99@bnu.edu.cn or cap007@yahoo.com. My phone number is 86-13910959315.

Sincerely,

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read "Xiulan Zhang", on a light gray rectangular background.

Xiulan Zhang, Ph.D
Professor Emeritus, Founding Dean
Independent non-executive director, Tencent Holdings Ltd